

**The Impact of War-Related Future Uncertainty on the Academic Motivation of Ukrainian
University Students**

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Abstract

This study examined the relationship between war-related future uncertainty and academic motivation among Ukrainian university students during the ongoing Russian invasion. Twenty-seven students aged 16–23 completed an online questionnaire assessing perceived future uncertainty and academic motivation. Composite scores were created after reverse-coding designated items, and descriptive statistics and correlations were computed. Results indicated moderate levels of both future uncertainty ($M = 3.38$, $SD = 0.93$, $N = 27$) and academic motivation ($M = 3.28$, $SD = 0.93$, $N = 26$). A Pearson correlation revealed a small-to-moderate negative association between the two variables, $r(24) = -.34$, $p = .09$, indicating that greater uncertainty tended to correspond with reduced motivation. Although this relationship did not reach statistical significance, its direction aligns with theoretical expectations based on Future Time Perspective (FTP) theory. Implications for academic support in wartime contexts are discussed.

The Impact of War-Related Future Uncertainty on the Academic Motivation of Ukrainian

Introduction

The full-scale Russian invasion of Ukraine has profoundly disrupted the daily lives, psychological stability, and future expectations of millions of Ukrainians, including university students. For young adults in higher education, the war has created conditions of chronic uncertainty, instability, and emotional strain. These stressors influence not only mental health but also core aspects of educational functioning, such as academic engagement, persistence, and motivation. Recent empirical studies show that Ukrainian university students experience elevated levels of stress, anxiety, and insecurity compared to pre-war cohorts, and these psychological burdens translate into weakened academic performance and concentration.

Academic motivation - an essential determinant of persistence, performance, and long-term educational success - is especially sensitive to such crises. One of the key psychological mechanisms through which war conditions may affect academic behavior is **Future Time Perspective (FTP)**: the cognitive - emotional process by which individuals imagine, organize, and evaluate their future goals. Extensive international research shows that a positive, structured future orientation supports higher motivation, persistence, and self-regulated learning (Andre et al., 2018; Lens et al., 2012). Conversely, when an individual's future becomes unpredictable or threatened, their willingness to invest effort in long-term goals - including education - tends to decline.

Recent Ukrainian studies highlight that the war has significantly distorted students' future orientation. Lazurenko et al. (2023) found that university students displayed a notably reduced future-positive perspective and increased fatalism, especially among those displaced from high-risk regions. Similarly, Kuchyn et al. (2024), studying medical PhD students in wartime Kyiv,

showed that uncertainty about post-war prospects - employment, stability, international mobility, and research opportunities - shapes academic motivation in complex ways. While some students experience strengthened purpose, many report that chronic uncertainty undermines their long-term academic commitment.

Broader wartime research further indicates that academic functioning is tightly linked to psychological distress and students' perceptions of their prospects. Polyvianaia et al. (2025) and Kurapov (2024) report persistently high levels of distress among Ukrainian university students, which negatively affect academic outcomes. However, relatively few studies have examined future-related cognitions - specifically **war-related future uncertainty** - as a distinct factor influencing academic motivation.

Given the theoretical importance of FTP for educational motivation and the unique context of prolonged wartime conditions, this study examines how Ukrainian students' subjective sense of unpredictability about their future relates to their motivation to engage in university studies.

Research Question

To what extent is war-related future uncertainty associated with academic motivation among Ukrainian university students?

Hypothesis

H1: Higher levels of war-related future uncertainty will be associated with lower levels of academic motivation.

Method

Research Design

This study employed a quantitative, cross-sectional correlational design to examine the relationship between war-related future uncertainty and academic motivation among Ukrainian university students. As wartime conditions cannot be manipulated, a correlational approach is appropriate for assessing natural psychological associations.

Participants

Twenty-seven Ukrainian university students participated voluntarily ($N = 27$). Participants ranged in age from 16 to 23 years ($M = 19.85$, $SD = 1.61$). The sample consisted of 63% female students, 29.6% male students, and 7.4% who preferred not to disclose their gender. Students represented multiple years of study at both bachelor's and master's levels. At the time of participation, 40.7% reported studying outside Ukraine due to displacement, relocation, or mobility opportunities caused by the war.

Materials and Measures

The online questionnaire included demographic questions and 10 Likert-scale items rated from 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).

Future Uncertainty Scale (3 items)

Measured difficulty forming long-term plans and perceived unpredictability about post-graduation life. Example item:

“I feel that making long-term plans right now is pointless because of the war.”

Academic Motivation Scale (3 items)

Measured motivation to attend classes, engagement in self-study, and persistence. Example item:

“I feel motivated to attend my seminars and lectures.”

Reverse-Coding and Composite Scores

Two items required reverse-coding so that higher scores reflected higher levels of the intended construct:

- Q5 (clarity of future plans → future uncertainty)
- Q9 (doubts about completing the degree → academic motivation)

Reverse coding formula: **6 – original score**.

Composite scale scores were computed as the mean of the relevant items. Higher values indicate greater future uncertainty and higher academic motivation.

Procedure

Data were collected through an anonymous online survey distributed via Google Forms.

Participation was voluntary, and participants provided informed consent before beginning the questionnaire. The survey required approximately 5 minutes. After data collection, responses were exported to CSV format and analyzed using JASP and Python (pandas and matplotlib) to compute descriptive statistics, composite scores, and Pearson correlations.

Ethical Considerations

The study followed principles of voluntary participation, anonymity, and minimal psychological risk. No identifying information was collected. Given the wartime context, care was taken to avoid sensitive or potentially traumatic content.

Results

Descriptive Statistics

Descriptive statistics for all individual Likert-scale items are presented in **Table 1**. Across the items, means ranged from 2.22 to 3.63. The lowest mean was for Q9 (doubts about completing the degree), indicating that although some students reported questioning their studies, this concern was not dominant. The highest mean was Q6 (difficulty planning professional future), reflecting the strong impact of wartime uncertainty on career planning. One participant did not provide a response for the self-study item (Q10). As a result, the Academic Motivation composite and the correlation analysis were based on 26 valid cases.

Composite scale means showed:

The Future Uncertainty scale had a mean of 3.38 (SD = 0.93, N = 27), while the **Academic Motivation** scale had a mean of 3.28 (SD = 0.93, N = 26).

These values align with recent research finding that students maintain moderate motivation despite disrupted planning capacities.

Table 1

Descriptive Statistics

	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8	Q9	Q10
<i>Valid</i>	27	27	27	27	27	26
<i>Missing</i>	0	0	0	0	0	1
<i>Mean</i>	2.81	3.63	3.33	3.22	2.22	2.88
	5	0	3	2	2	5
<i>Std.</i>	1.41	1.04	1.33	1.42	1.08	1.14

Descriptive Statistics

	Q5	Q6	Q7	Q8	Q9	Q10
<i>Deviation</i>	5	3	0	3	6	3
<i>Minimum</i>	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00
	0	0	0	0	0	0
<i>Maximum</i>	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00	5.00
	0	0	0	0	0	0

Table 2

Descriptive Statistics

	<i>Future_Uncertaint</i>	<i>Academic_Motivatio</i>
	<i>y</i>	<i>n</i>
<i>Valid</i>	27	26
<i>Missing</i>	0	0
<i>Mean</i>	3.383	3.280
<i>Std.</i>		
<i>Deviation</i>	0.928	0.920
<i>Minimum</i>	1.333	1.333
<i>Maximum</i>	4.667	4.667

Correlation Between Future Uncertainty and Academic Motivation

A Pearson correlation analysis indicated no statistically significant association between Future Uncertainty and Academic Motivation, $r(24) = -.34$, $p = .09$.

Table 3

Correlation

<i>Pearson's Correlations</i>				
			Pearson's r	p
Future_Uncertainty	-	Academic_Motivation	-0.334	.088

Note. N = 26 due to one missing value on Q10

Although not statistically significant at $p < .05$, the direction of the effect supports theoretical expectations: reduced clarity or predictability about one's future tends to weaken academic engagement during crisis conditions. Given the modest sample size, statistical power may have been insufficient to detect smaller effects.

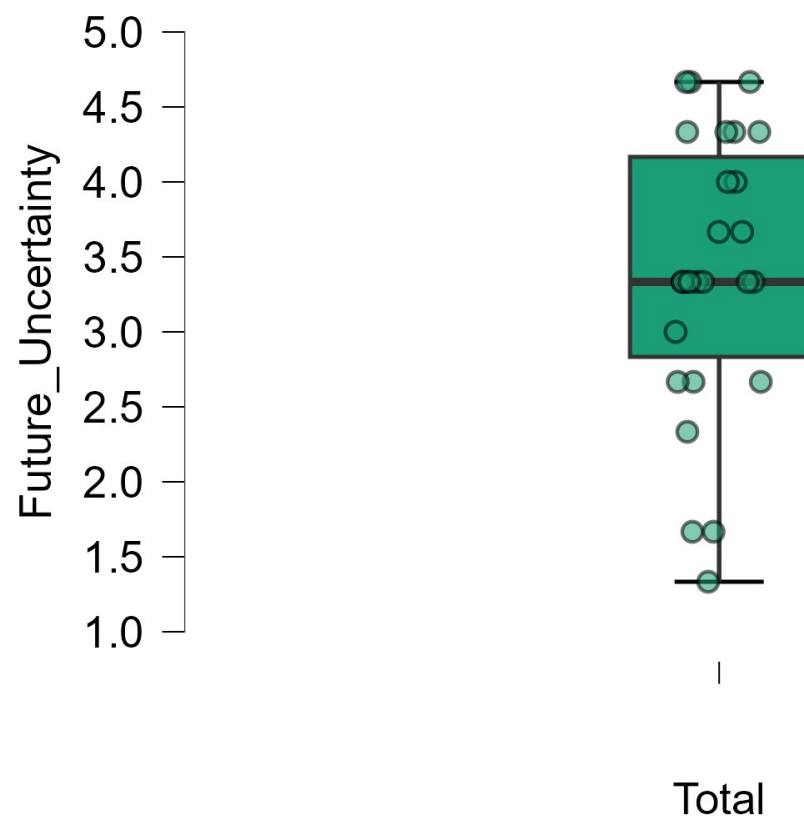
Graphical Representation

Figure 1 visualizes the distribution of the composite variables using boxplots. Both variables show moderate variability and relatively symmetric distributions, with no extreme outliers.

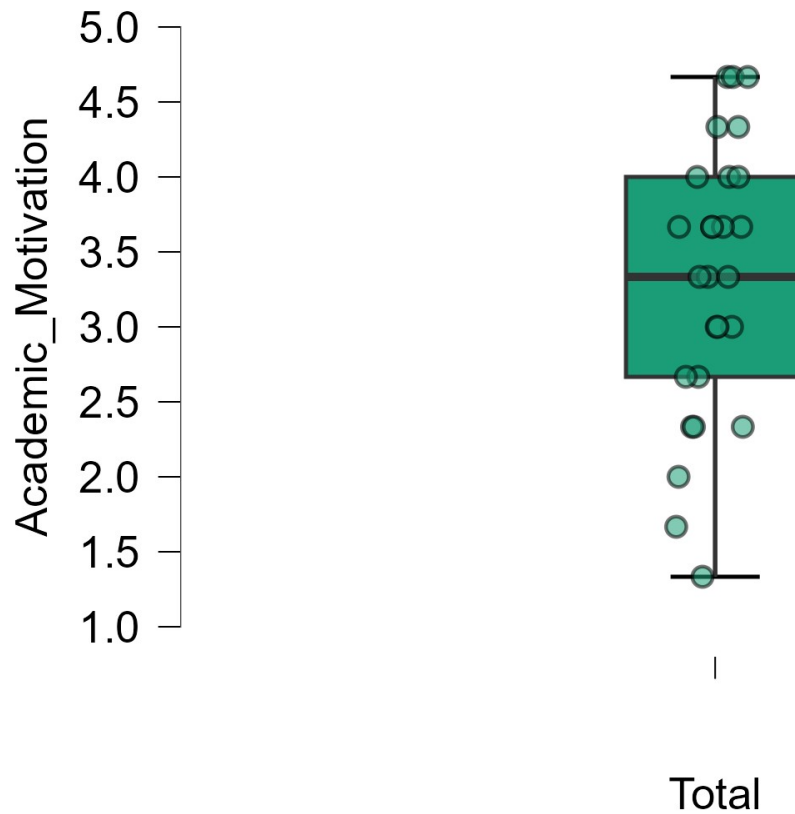
Figure 1

Boxplots Depicting Future Uncertainty and Academic Motivation (N = 26)

Future_Uncertainty



Academic_Motivation



Discussion

The purpose of this study was to examine the relationship between war-related future uncertainty and academic motivation among Ukrainian university students. The findings partially support the hypothesis.

Interpretation of Findings

The correlation between future uncertainty and academic motivation was negative ($r(24) = -.34$), suggesting that as students feel less able to plan their futures, their study motivation tends to

decline. This aligns with Future Time Perspective theory, which argues that a coherent vision of the future is required to sustain academic effort (Lens et al., 2012; Andre et al., 2018).

Despite this, descriptive statistics showed that students maintained moderate academic motivation even under high uncertainty. This reflects earlier findings by Kuchyn et al. (2024), who noted that for many students, continuing to study functions as psychological stabilization and resistance during the war.

Practical Implications

Universities and educational support services may need to:

- provide career counseling adapted to wartime instability
- offer short-term academic planning tools
- strengthen psychological support services
- help students maintain a sense of continuity and purpose

Interventions that clarify immediate steps—not long-term plans—may be especially beneficial in a context where the future is unpredictable.

Limitations

This study has several limitations.

- The small sample size ($N = 27$) reduced statistical power.
- Convenience sampling limits generalizability.
- The sample was predominantly female, potentially excluding perspectives of male students affected by mobilization.
- The cross-sectional design prevents causal inference.
- **Most importantly:** the study used short, self-constructed scales rather than validated psychometric instruments, which may limit measurement reliability.

Conclusion

The war in Ukraine has created a context of deep unpredictability for university students. This study suggests that although students struggle to plan their futures, they maintain moderate academic motivation. A negative relationship was observed between future uncertainty and motivation, highlighting that the inability to visualize post-war life may pose a risk to educational persistence.

For universities, academic support should extend beyond course delivery to include assistance with short-term planning and psychological resilience. Future research should employ larger samples, validated scales, and longitudinal designs to examine how this relationship evolves over time as the conflict continues.

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